INT. SUBWAY TRAIN - NIGHT (11:30PM DEC 30TH)

The last train of the night hums through the dark tunnel. Sparse passengers. Fluorescent lights flicker faintly.

ETHAN MILLER (37), exhausted, slumps in the corner seat. He stares at his phone screen. It reads "Monthly Sales Performance: -17%."

Ethan exhales sharply. His phone vibrates. A voice message from MOM (70) .

MOM (V.O.): *Hey honey, I made your favorite dumplings. They're in the freezer. Don't forget to eat, okay? I know you've been working late.*

Ethan's eyes glisten.

Ethan: *Yeah. I will. Thanks, Mom.*

Deletes.

Ethan: *Mom, I might get promoted. Busy lately. I'll visit this weekend.*

He hesitates. Sends it. He stares at the screen. A lie.

The train slows. An OLD MAN (70), wearing faded work clothes and carrying a heavy toolbox, boards and sits across from Ethan.

The man smells faintly of oil and dust. Ethan instinctively shifts away, placing his briefcase between them. The Old Man doesn't react. He takes out a worn notebook and writes carefully with a short pencil stub.

Ethan glances over. Strange symbols. Numbers.

OLD MAN
Young man… may I borrow a pen? Mine's worn down.

Ethan hesitates, then pulls out a black metal company pen. He hands it over.

OLD MAN
Thank you.

The scratching of pen on paper echoes in the near-empty carriage.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Next stop: Central Park. Please prepare to disembark.

The Old Man returns the pen.

OLD MAN
That’s a good pen. Not many people take care of one like this.

ETHAN
How can you tell?

OLD MAN
See the scratches inside the cap? You open it one-handed. And the clip bent just enough to catch a notebook. Pens start to look like the people who use them.

Ethan looks at the pen, stunned. He never noticed that.

ETHAN
You work late too?

OLD MAN
I repair clocks. The old tower downtown stopped three days ago. Just fixed it.

Ethan thinks about the century-old clocks he passes daily, never looking up.

ETHAN
Is it difficult?

OLD MAN
Not really. Every gear’s got its place. A second too fast or too slow, and it throws everything off. Life is the same.

Ethan forces a thin smile. The train begins to slow. The doors slide open with a hollow chime. The Old Man rises, lifting himself carefully, and steps onto the platform.

Ethan exhales. Then his eyes drift across the empty seat opposite him. The toolbox is still there.

ETHAN
Hey sir! Your tool box!

The train is already pulling away. Through the window, the platform recedes into darkness. Ethan opens the toolbox carefully, searching for some kind of contact information. Inside are neatly arranged precision tools and a worn notebook lying open. He flips to the last page. Written in fresh black ink:

Adjustment Record #1374
23:47 — Last train
Target encountered.
Observation: Exhausted but kind. Under pressure, integrity intact.
Recommendation: Grant opportunity.

ETHAN
Target?

He looks up. The train car is nearly empty. A faint ticking begins. TICK. TICK. TICK. The ticking grows louder. The digital clock above the door flips: 00:00.

The lights flicker. Ethan blinks. A wave of dizziness hits him. The carriage seems to tilt. He grabs the seat to steady himself. A hand enters frame.

OLD MAN (O.S.)
Young man. Your pen.

Ethan looks up. The Old Man sits across from him again, calm, as if nothing happened. Ethan takes it slowly. His eyes drift upward to the train display: December 1 — 00:00

Ethan freezes. He pulls out his phone. The notification bar is empty. No missed calls. No angry emails. No rejected proposals. He opens the sales dashboard app. It displays monthly performance: 0%

Ethan’s breathing quickens. He now understands.

Thirty days left. He knows exactly what will happen. Which client will hesitate, which call he almost didn’t make, and which opportunity he let slip.

This time, he won’t. A slow smile spreads across his face. He opens his chat with Mom.

ETHAN: *Mom… I’ll come home this weekend for dumplings. And I’ve got some good news coming.*

He glances at the glowing 0% on his screen.

ETHAN: *This month… I won’t let you down.*

He sends it. The train moves steadily through the tunnel. Ethan looks forward.

Ready.

FADE OUT.